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1
The Conflict

Part of the problem with formulating a solution for the difficulties of Northern Ireland is the extent to which the history of Ireland is itself contested. This chapter offers a whirlwind historical tour to familiarize the reader with the basis of the conflict.

The first, loose, system of 'government' was via tribal Gaelic chiefs, followed by Christianity in the fifth century. Although the Gaels are generally seen as the 'native' Irish, having arrived in the fifth century, they were also 'invaders of Ireland' (Boyce, 1991, p. 26), although it has been claimed that the invasion was largely peaceful (Cronin, 2001). Unionist-leaning authors assert that the arrival of the Gaels was preceded by the settlement of various Scottish tribes in Ulster (Adamson, 1974; Wilson, 1989). Even if the 'we were here first' arguments cannot be resolved, it can be asserted that Ireland has never been entirely united, Gaelic and free.

The origins of political problems can be traced back as far as the loose establishment of British colonial rule in Ireland in the twelfth century. This was followed in the early seventeenth century by the arrival of Protestant settlers, mainly from Scotland, in the north-eastern part of Ireland. Divisions between Scottish Protestants and Irish Catholics became apparent after the plantation of Ulster by the Scots from 1609. Post-plantation, the next four centuries of politics in Ireland concerned the fermenting and attempted management of division, in what has often been seen as a zero-sum game between, broadly, Protestant British unionists and Catholic Irish nationalists, with these two traditions coexisting uneasily in the north-east corner of the island.

The struggle for Irish independence from Britain began as early as 1641 and was continued in the 1798 rebellion. That uprising was led by Wolfe Tone, who came from a Church of Ireland background, had Catholic links and was a Deist. At this stage the link between Irish nationalism and Roman Catholicism was far from automatic. In parts

of the country, however, the uprising did have a sectarian flavour, with, for example, Protestants being killed by the rebels at Wexford (Jackson, 1999, p. 18). Britain's attempt to consolidate its rule throughout Ireland via the 1800 Act of Union bought time for colonial rule.

The forces of Irish nationalism grew during the nineteenth century, fuelled by famine and contests over the ownership of land. Concurrently, economic development in Ulster highlighted the sense of difference felt by northern Protestants. Anxious to placate constitutional Irish nationalists, the Liberal government attempted to give Ireland semi-autonomy within the British Empire by means of its Home Rule Bill of 1886. Protestants in the north-east corner of Ireland were enraged by what they saw as a threat to their political, religious, economic and cultural liberty. Formed in 1905, the Ulster Unionist Council united the political and religious forces of unionism, effectively fusing a political organization, the Unionist Party, with a religious movement, the Orange Order. Backed by the vast numerical and military strength of the 'paramilitary' Ulster Volunteer Force, Ulster unionism was a virulent force that could not easily be absorbed into any semi-independent Ireland. Unionism's strength defeated the Home Rule Bills of 1886, 1893 and 1912.

Hitherto weaker than Ulster unionism, Irish nationalism had also grown in virulence as a result of the response of the British government to the 1916 Easter Rising against British rule. Although the rebellion was weak and largely confined to Dublin, the subsequent execution of several of its leaders gave the rebels a hitherto unknown sympathy. The partition of Ireland emerged as an unsatisfactory but pragmatic option to acknowledge the competing strengths of unionism and nationalism.

It is here that history is again contested. For unionists, partition – although initially not desired, given that unionists favoured the *status quo* – was justified. According to this view, the six-county country of Northern Ireland had democratic legitimacy as its creation reflected the balance of political forces. Unionists won 69 per cent of the votes in the six counties that were to form Northern Ireland under the 1920 Government of Ireland Act. Nationalists had a fundamentally different reading of the legitimacy of partition. Campaigning for an independent, united Ireland, Sinn Fein won 73 of the 105 parliamentary seats in the 1918 Westminster election, the last occasion on which the people of the island voted as a single unit. A further six seats were gained by Home Rule nationalists. For republicans, partition gave

veto rights over a democratic election to a national minority, Irish unionists. In response Sinn Fein established *Dail Eireann* and refused to recognize continued British rule, which continued via the parliaments in Dublin and Belfast. As IRA activity soared, the British government conceded greater independence to the 26-county southern state via the 1921 Anglo-Irish Treaty. However the island remained partitioned, with a unionist-dominated, devolved parliament governing the north and the Irish governing the south, which remained within the British Empire.

Sinn Fein and the IRA split over whether to accept the Anglo-Irish Treaty, leading to one of the bloodiest episodes of Irish history: the civil war of 1922–23. The defeat of the antitreaty forces was perhaps inevitable, given the military and political resources available to the forces of the new Irish Free State. To these were added the moral resources of the Catholic Church, which threatened excommunication to those republicans who wished to prolong the war. Although hostility to the 26-county Irish Free State was maintained by diehard republicans, even the antitreaty forces, led by Eamon de Valera, had taken the constitutional route by 1927, with de Valera's Fianna Fail entering *Dail Eireann* as an opposition party and then forming a government after the 1932 Irish election. De Valera adjusted the workings of the treaty to establish greater independence for the 26 counties, the transition to a republic being completed by (pro-treaty) Fine Gael in 1949. However the Irish government could do little about partition, other than to ensure that the 1937 constitution formally refused recognition of Northern Ireland as a legitimate political entity by refering to the pending 'reintegration of the national territory'. Armed campaigns to force the withdrawal of the British government's claim to Northern Ireland were continued by militant republicans on a small, sporadic scale, the border campaign of 1956–62 causing 18 deaths but producing no political dividends. As part of a cyclical pattern, to be repeated at the end of the twentieth century, formerly militant republicans adopted parliamentary strategies, denouncing and abandoning those who continued to pursue Irish unity by violent means.

From civil rights to insurrection

Although Northern Ireland was always an insecure province, it appeared for several decades that the 1920 Government of Ireland Act

and the 1921 Anglo-Irish Treaty might have brought fairly peaceful closure to the Irish question. Although a cold war existed between north and south, with politics frozen, there seemed that little could be done to alter the *status quo*. Northern nationalists, trapped within what quickly developed into a unionist-dominated enclave, did not like Northern Ireland and loathed the discrimination they endured. The extent of that discrimination is contested, as highlighted by the pioneering work of Rose (1971) and the later partial exoneration of the unionist government (Wilson, 1989). However the fact that discrimination did exist can scarcely be disputed (Farrell, 1980). Despite seeing themselves as second-class citizens, nationalists were not sufficiently motivated by border concerns to offer much support to the IRA's campaign of the 1950s. The very modest unionist reformist agenda of the 1960s, developed by the prime minister, Terrence O'Neill, raised nationalist hopes of better treatment. Reformism opened divisions within unionism, yet to heal, over the most appropriate means of securing the union. To some degree the debate within unionism took on a class form, as enlightened patricians treated nationalists with kindness in an attempt to entice them into the structures of the state. Other unionists continued to view nationalists as the enemy within, aided in ideological terms by an irredentist southern state.

Increasingly willing participants in the province, but not in its unionist form, nationalists began to agitate for civil rights during the late 1960s. The Northern Ireland Civil Rights Association (NICRA), a broad body straddling the social classes, provided an umbrella organization for the movement. It had a mainly middle-class leadership, although the idea that the middle classes directed the civil rights campaign has been refuted (Dixon, 2001). Although some liberal unionists joined in the early stages, the movement struggled to attract Protestant support. Many unionists took the jaundiced view of a later leader of the Ulster Unionist Party, David Trimble, that the civil rights campaign was 'really just the Republican movement in another guise' (Coogan, 1995, p. 63).

In reality NICRA was a disparate and often uneasy coalition of nationalists, republicans and socialists, sometimes with little in common other than a desire to confront a discriminatory unionist regime. Its 'members' (the term exaggerates the extent of organization as NICRA acted as little more than a somewhat ineffective umbrella) included communists, socialists, non-aligned radicals, working-class non-ideological Catholic 'defenders' (later to join the ranks of the

Provisional IRA), middle-class moderate Catholics (later to form the Social Democratic Labour Party, SDLP), veteran Republican IRA sympathizers, trade unionists and a sprinkling of liberal unionists. Indeed the civil rights movement was a more disparate coalition than the combination of sectarian orange and relatively moderate elements who comprised the unionist regime at Stormont. Unionist rule contained a range of discriminatory practices ranging from the petty to the malevolent and veering from veiled to blatant. Farrell (1983) highlights the insecure nature of the state, in which a large number of Protestants were employed in the police force to ward off a supposed threat from nationalists. The perception of threat was perhaps greater than the reality; the IRA's border campaign of the 1950s attracted little interest and fizzled out amid internal acrimony and disillusionment. Nationalists did not like the border and partition, but they were insufficiently aroused to take to arms to bring about its abolition.

Bew *et al.* (1996) acknowledge the clear existence of discrimination, but indicate that the unionist government presiding over such practices was not a monolith. Discrimination arose partly from the adoption of populist positions by sections of the unionist leadership, stances that sometimes created internal tensions. Discrimination against the nationalist population was practised in the public sector and condoned in some parts of private industry (Whyte, 1983). Motivations varied from contempt for Catholics to more political reasons associated with the alleged republican threat to the state (Darby, 1976). Nationalist self-exclusion, particularly through abstention from Stormont, is claimed to be a contributory factor, although it is difficult to see what benefits would have accrued to participation, given Unionist majoritarianism (Buckland, 1981).

O'Neill's reformist agenda was not hugely dissimilar from that espoused by NICRA. The Northern Ireland prime minister shared its desire to reform the local electoral franchise, which disproportionately disenfranchised Catholics through the requirement that voters should be rate-paying home-owners. O'Neill was also desirous of ending the gerrymandering of electoral boundaries and advocated the suspension of its least subtle exponent, Derry City Corporation. O'Neill's attempted restructuring of unionism lacked solid support among the working class. His patrician appeal to Protestants that they should treat Catholics well 'in order that they will live like Protestants' was offensive to the minority community and failed to assuage uncertainty among unionists (*Belfast Telegraph*, 10 May 1969). O'Neill's project was also

based on economic modernization, but he operated in a polity in which the division of spoils had always taken importance over the aggregate story.

The rising figure of Ian Paisley, leader of his own inventions – the Free Presbyterian Church, the Protestant Unionist Party and, from 1971, the Democratic Unionist Party – held political appeal for doubters among the loyalist working class and religious appeal for rural evangelicals (Bruce, 1986). Ideological divisions were apparent within the unionist regime from the outset; however these divisions were kept in check by a combination of the voting system (which discouraged minor parties), unity of purpose, a lack of class-based challenges and the void in nationalist politics. As civil disobedience replaced sullen abstention as the means of nationalist political participation, unionism imploded.

The main response to the civil rights movement from the unionist government was to deploy the Royal Ulster Constabulary and its reserves, the B Specials, to prevent marches taking place along illegal routes. With the police force unsupported by most nationalists, demands for civil rights developed into civil strife in 1968 and 1969. The political limits of O'Neillism were highlighted by the security-based response. O'Neill had no plans to change Northern Ireland's security forces, although in 1969, when the British government was obliged to send in troops, the B Specials were disbanded. The Hunt Report on the disturbances of 1969 suggested that the Northern Ireland police force should be disarmed, a recommendation that was first ignored and then abandoned when the IRA was reborn (Hunt Report, 1969). When sending in troops to quell disturbances, the British government was aware that a quick fix to Northern Ireland's problems was unlikely. Indeed Prime Minister Harold Wilson, who was privately critical of the unionist government, believed an army presence would be required for at least seven years (Pimlott, 1992).

The paramilitary campaigns

The series of security-based responses were unaccompanied by serious political thinking. In this vacuum the Provisional IRA, which had amounted to a mere handful of 'dissident' republican ultras upon its formation in January 1970, began to flourish. A combination of structural and episodic forces gave rise to the birth of the Provisional

IRA. The organization was committed to the defence of northern nationalists, but insisted that its primary loyalty was to the provisional Irish government of 1919. How the Provisional IRA is defined depends on the level of analysis. Among its 'foot soldiers', particularly in urban areas, the events of 1969 to 1972 dominated. In this respect Anthony McIntyre (a former member of the Provisional IRA) is justified in asserting that the organization was rooted in northern defenderism, rather than being a lineal descendant of the earlier IRAs, which saw all legitimacy as flowing from the 1919 *Dail Eireann* (McIntyre, 2001).

McIntryre's argument does explain the motivation of many who joined the Provisional IRA in its formative years. Nonetheless, among the leadership of the Provisionals, which included figures such as Ruairi O'Bradaigh and Sean McStiofain, there was faithful adherence to the ideals of 1916–19. The first utterance of the Provisional IRA was 'We declare our allegiance to the thirty-two county Irish Republic, proclaimed at Easter 1916, established by the first Dail Eireann in 1919, overthrown by force of arms in 1922 and suppressed to this day by the existing British-imposed six-county and twenty-six-county partition states' (*Irish News*, 29 December 1969). This does not invalidate McIntyre's analysis, given that the same statement lamented the 'failure to provide the maximum defence possible' for nationalists, but it can be argued that there was a duality of purpose to the Provisional IRA (MacStiofain, 1975, p. 143).

Given the adherence to traditional republicanism, the claim that the Provisional IRA began as a 'force for the self-protection of the Catholic population' is a partial presentation (Cronin, 2001, p. 234). The Provisionals were unsuccessful in their protective role, a self-ascribed duty that nonetheless had useful recruitment and propaganda qualities. Their offensive role, designed to end British sovereignty over Northern Ireland, also failed, although it yielded advances for nationalists within the province that constitutional nationalism might not have obtained. The split in the IRA that led to the formation of the Provisionals, occurred after the leader of what became known as the Official IRA, Çathal Goulding, made two proposals to the IRA's 'General Army Convention' in 1969, a grand term given the moribund nature of the organization. Goulding argued for the establishment of a broad 'National Liberation Front' that would bring the IRA into alliances with other left-wing groups, including the Irish Communist Party. He also wished to end republican abstention from *Dail Eireann*, Stormont and Westminster (Horgan and Taylor, 1997b). The latter

proposal would have meant the end of traditional republicanism and it was primarily for this reason that the Provisional IRA was formed. The plight of northern nationalists was acknowledged as a contributory factor, but the end of abstentionism, breaches of the IRA constitution and the shift towards 'communist' politics were cited by the Provisional IRA as justifications for the republican schism in 1969–70.

Although the split has been seen as one of southern Official IRA versus northern Provisional IRA, the leadership of the latter included a number of southerners. Furthermore, those northerners who were seen as 'Catholic defenders' were often veteran republicans, (for example Billy McKee) who maintained a lifelong allegiance to the republic established in 1918–19. New recruits were informed that 'the Army [IRA] is the direct representative of the 1918 Dail Eireann parliament ... the legal and lawful government of the Irish Republic' (Coogan, 1995, p. 208). The Provisionals therefore had a historical reason for their existence, based on the orthodox republican fundamentalism and militarism of Padraig Pearse, in which, according to one critic, 'the people and their governments counted for nothing' after 1918 (Laffan, 1999, p. 458). For the initial leaders of the Provisional IRA the events of 1968–69 were a vindication of their view that the northern state could never be viable. They sought to translate nationalist disaffection with the unionist regime into a push to deal with the 'unfinished business' of 1916–22.

From the summer of 1969 until April 1970, Northern Ireland was relatively calm and the Provisional IRA recruited few members in its formative months, but then a combination of sectarian rioting and a catalogue of poor judgements about responsive actions by the British Army (encouraged by the ailing Stormont government) fuelled IRA recruitment. These actions, taken amid a deteriorating political and security situation, included the 1970 Falls curfew, the introduction of internment in 1971 and the nadir, Bloody Sunday, in January 1972.

The commitment of the Provisional IRA to armed force and the security blunders by the British Army and RUC led to a devastating paramilitary campaign of violence. This whirlwind of loyalist violence was mainly retaliatory, but also contained offensive elements and was overwhelmingly sectarian. The IRA claimed that its purpose was to 'shoot at the uniform', although in the mid 1970s, a number of its own volunteers wondered whether the organization had descended into a sectarian war (Bean and Hayes, 2001). A breakdown of killings by republicans indicates that uniformed enemies were their main targets,

but not so decisively as to eradicate the anxiety of those who wished the war to be conducted only within that parameter. The combined British Army, Royal Ulster Constabulary (RUC) and Ulster Defence Regiment deaths amounted to 1008 between 1969 and 1999, or just 27 per cent of the 3744 killings during this period.

The Provisional IRA was an uneasy coalition of volunteers, fusing dedicated republicans, Catholic sectarians, romantic nationalists, virulent anticommunists, outright militarists, socialists and communists within its ranks. Some of its left-wing volunteers joined remnants of the Official IRA to form the Irish National Liberation Army (INLA), an ostensibly left-wing version of the IRA, but one that appeared equally keen to participate in actions that were seen by opponents as largely sectarian. A consequence of the split of 1970 was the perpetuation of a series of deadly republican feuds, particularly between Provisionals and Officials, for much of the 1970s. These quietened in the 1980s, when the IRA and INLA began to tolerate each other and conducted similar operations. In 1992 the IRA moved decisively against a republican offshoot, the misleadingly titled Irish People's Liberation Organization (IPLO), another organization offering leftist rhetoric but dealing mainly in criminality and gangsterism.

The Provisional IRA's offensive, which began in the summer of 1970 and gathered momentum early in 1971, appeared to pay dividends. With the unionist government suspended from March 1972 and the British government prepared to negotiate with the Provisional IRA by the summer of 1972, there was belief among some republicans in the imminence of victory. For republicans, the British government's desire to retain control over Northern Ireland had not been seriously tested since partition. There was little sign of a strong commitment to other colonies; rather there was much global evidence of withdrawal. Yet the introduction of direct British rule represented military and political setbacks for the Provisionals. It provided, albeit slowly, greater coherence to the counterinsurgency strategy of the British Army, unfettered by the political posturing of unionists. For many moderate nationalists the move also removed the immediate source of resentment, the unionist regime. Whilst disaffection with the British government and its security apparatus easily replaced this resentment amongst many working-class nationalists, the relative unity of purpose among the nationalist population, as seen in its desire to overthrow the unionist government, was no longer in place. As noted earlier, although the civil rights campaign contained disparate elements it

engendered a sense of community solidarity. After the collapse of the Stormont government, however, particularly with the rise of a moderate Catholic middle class, the nationalist community was an imagined community, a varied and heterogeneous people. Although nationalists aspired to Irish unity, the strength of their desire varied enormously. While this was not reducible merely to social class, it did reflect differences between those who had not done too badly from the province and those who continued to endure poor living standards. Formed in 1970, the Social Democratic and Labour Party (SDLP) offered a political outlet for mainly middle-class nationalists who preferred constitutional politics. The party also offered a platform for those who preferred labourist politics, even if the party soon essentially became a vehicle of Catholic nationalism. Those who could see no future in the province had the option of joining the Provisional IRA.

Loyalist paramilitaries operated under a variety of names. Surprisingly the Ulster Defence Association (UDA), a mass organization of 40 000 members in the 1970s, remained legal until 1992, despite the fact that its paramilitary wing, the Ulster Freedom Fighters (UFF), busied itself with sectarian killings throughout the conflict, mainly Catholics chosen at random. This strategy was designed to deter the working-class nationalist community, which was seen as a homogeneous entity, from offering support to the IRA. A similar pattern of assassination was followed by the Ulster Volunteer Force (UVF), a numerically pale imitation of the mass movement of the same name much earlier in the twentieth century, but nonetheless capable of instilling fear into Catholics through its activities. Loyalist violence emphasized to the British government and nationalists the potential price of withdrawal from Northern Ireland, stressing that movement towards a united, independent Ireland would lead to civil war. Although loyalist paramilitarism often lacked the discipline usually displayed by the Provisional IRA, periodically lapsing into drug dealing or feuding, its proponents believed that it was decisive in winning the 'war' in its final stages. Loyalist paramilitaries refined their targets in the late 1980s and early 1990s, targeting Sinn Fein and IRA members in addition to randomly selected Catholics. During the 1980s in particular, there was collusion between branches of the security forces and loyalist paramilitaries, as detailed in the Stevens Report of 2003 (see Chapter 10).

As early as 1977 the IRA recognized that immediate British withdrawal was not on the agenda. The movement had already shown

interest in direct discussions with loyalist groups on the possibility of marrying some loyalists' desire for an independent Northern Ireland with the republican belief in the need for a federal Ireland. However talks between an independent loyalist, Desmond Boal, and a former IRA chief of staff, Sean MacBride, acting at the behest of loyalist and republican paramilitaries respectively, failed to bridge the differences. At the 1977 Bodenstown commemoration speech, Jimmy Drumm, a leading figure in the republican movement, emphasized that the belief in an imminent British withdrawal had been an illusion. This illusion had not merely been promoted by the leadership, but had also been harboured by ordinary volunteers. Drumm's speech heralded a new approach, based on more subtle military means and designed to maintain a long war. The new approach was a necessary riposte to the military pressure placed on the IRA by Secretary of State Roy Mason, who was more interested in squeezing the IRA 'like a tube of toothpaste' than in fostering political initiatives (quoted in Urban, 1992, p. 11).

As the IRA reorganized from loose brigades into smaller, more secretive cell structures its internal security tightened. However it was to be another four years before the impetus for a long war properly developed. Electoralism began to permeate the movement, largely by accident rather than design. Following the death of ten republicans on prison hunger strike in 1981, Sinn Fein gathered political strength after a prolonged struggle for the restoration of its political status, which had been withdrawn in 1975. The dying hunger striker, Bobby Sands, stood successfully as the Anti H Block candidate in a Westminster by-election in May 1981, when nationalists of various shades rallied to the cause and Sands was unopposed by other nationalists or republicans. After Sands' death his election agent, Owen Carron, won the subsequent by-election.

One year later Sinn Fein began to contest elections and won 40 per cent of the nationalist vote. The extent of support for Sinn Fein indicated that the desire for armed struggle to achieve unity was not the preserve of a tiny minority. A vote for Sinn Fein during that period was interpreted as endorsement of the IRA's paramilitary campaign. Indeed Sinn Fein's 1982 *ard fheis* made clear that support for the IRA by Sinn Fein electoral candidates was a necessary precondition for their candidature.

Sinn Fein and the IRA developed as 'symbiotic movements' with a considerable overlap of personnel (Horgan and Taylor, 1997a, p. 2).

This allowed the development of the 'armalite and ballot box' strategy, famously if inadvertently articulated by Sinn Fein's Danny Morrison at the 1981 *ard fheis*. Eventually electoralism was to subsume the militarism of the republican movement. Such a development had been predicted by 1970–83 the president of Sinn Fein, Ruairi O'Bradaigh, after the party's 1986 *ard fheis* decision to end abstention from *Dail Eireann*. O'Bradaigh immediately formed Republican Sinn Fein, a group that adhered to the historical principles outlined in 1918–19 and reiterated in 1970. He argued that the departure from the fundamental principle of refusing to recognize 'partition parliaments' was an attempt to ride two horses of constitutional and revolutionary politics, the ultimate destination of which was Stormont. Later, in 1998, O' Bradaigh would claim vindication of his predictions. Yet for most within the republican movement the failure to recognize the 26-county southern state amounted to outdated dogma, at variance from the thinking of the vast majority of Irish people. Recognition of the southern state was accompanied by pledges from the republican leadership that the war would continue, an assertion that was designed to reassure internal doubters but nullified any prospect of immediate electoral progress in the Irish Republic, where Sinn Fein captured only 2 per cent of the vote.

By 1988 there were clearer indications that the Provisional IRA was seeking a way out of the conflict. A series of meetings between the SDLP and Sinn Fein leaderships ended in disagreement, primarily over whether the British government could be regarded as a neutral actor. However the argument by the SDLP leader, John Hume, that the IRA's campaign was detrimental to Irish unity and to Sinn Fein's electoral fortunes was to impact on republicans. Unknown to participants, the Hume–Adams dialogue built on private initiatives by Gerry Adams as president of Sinn Fein. By the mid 1980s Adams was in contact, via an intermediary (Father Alec Reid, a Belfast priest), with the British and Irish governments in an attempt to construct a formula for Irish self-determination, which would not necessarily mean rapid British withdrawal from Northern Ireland (Moloney, 2002). The eventually agreed formula, as outlined in the 1993 Downing Street Declaration by the British and Irish governments, fell short of true self-determination, but nonetheless yielded an IRA ceasefire.

The IRA campaign, when measured in terms of financial and human cost, gathered strength in the run-up to the 1994 ceasefire. The

organization wished to demonstrate that it had not been defeated. Furthermore IRA 'spectaculars' might strengthen Sinn Fein's hand in any eventual negotiations. In 1991 the IRA came close to destroying the British cabinet in a mortar attack on Downing Street. Huge bomb explosions at the Baltic Exchange and the NatWest Tower in the financial centre of London caused hundreds of millions of pounds of damage. When the IRA temporarily called off its ceasefire in 1996 due to the exclusion of Sinn Fein from talks, the detonation of huge IRA bombs at Canary Wharf in London and in Manchester emphasized the continuing potency of the organization. Such actions later led the chair of Sinn Fein, Mitchel McLaughlin (2000), to claim that the IRA had 'stopped when it had never been stronger'. Nonetheless the bombings in the 1990s, and certainly those in 1996–97, were not efforts to force British withdrawal but were mainly concerned with securing a place for Sinn Fein in political negotiations and an eventual settlement, even though an agreement would fall short of republican objectives. In Northern Ireland, IRA violence ensured that the nationalist community paid a high price in terms of the response by loyalists. Actions such as the bombing of a fish shop on the loyalist Shankill in October 1993, killing nine plus the bomber, in a failed attempt to kill loyalist paramilitary leaders, were followed by indiscriminate loyalist retaliatory violence against Catholics.

The failure of political initiatives prior to the 1990s

Several broad theses have been advanced on British policy in Northern Ireland. The first is the existence of a discernible strategy of 'long withdrawal' from the province (Fisk, 1975; Kennedy-Pipe, 1997). The second is that Britain has no particular strategy other than to minimize its involvement and the cost to itself (Bew *et al.* 1996; Dixon, 2001). As such the 'policy' of the British government merely amounts to lowest common denominator politics, in which peace and political processes are conducted by harnessing willing participants if they can deliver relative stability. The third thesis is that a new Northern Irish politics has been created through a painfully slow policy learning process for political actors, including the British government (O'Leary, 1997). This culminated in a political settlement based on the consociational principle of power sharing with minority veto rights, linked

to broader political arrangements involving the totality of relationships between Northern Ireland and the Irish Republic, and the United Kingdom and the Irish Republic.

The lack of ambition in British policy from August 1969 to March 1972 can be attributed to structural factors. Devolution for Northern Ireland meant that interference by Westminster, although possible, was more likely to be waived in favour of a hands-off approach. It was difficult to raise Northern Ireland issues at Westminster, to the chagrin of a small number of Labour MPs but the indifference of almost all others. The recall of parliament to discuss the introduction of internment in 1971 was only the tenth such reconvention since the Second World War. Internment was favoured by the unionist government, tentatively backed by the British government and opposed by the British Army. Supporters who cited its success in the 1956–62 IRA campaign ignored several new factors. First, the IRA now possessed a strong northern urban base. Second, there was no prospect of a reciprocal arrangement with the Irish government, whose distaste for the unionist government was reflected in bellicose statements, if little else, other than isolated support for the provisionals, by sections of Fianna Fail. Third, army intelligence was inadequate as most Provisional IRA recruits were young and had no previous record of paramilitary or political activity. Fourth, as Kennedy-Pipe (1997, p. 58) notes, internment was a surrogate political strategy that assumed the removal of 'troublemakers' would solve a political problem. Finally, loyalist violence was now endemic, but internment would concentrate on the nationalist population and was thus seen as a highly partisan measure.

After Bloody Sunday it was apparent that the unionist government was doomed, so the introduction of direct rule from Westminster within two months came as little surprise. The imposition of direct rule allowed greater clarity in security policy and offered scope for political dialogue. Although the British government's insistence that it would 'not talk to terrorists' became a mantra, indirect dialogue was commonplace. During the 1970s, dialogue was even public. The leader of the Labour opposition, Harold Wilson, held talks with the leadership of the Provisional IRA in 1971, and in July 1972 the home secretary, William Whitelaw, met a Provisional IRA delegation. By recognizing the Provisional IRA the British government gave credence to the republicans' claim to be an army fighting a legitimate war, with the support of a sizeable section of the population. Given the republican absolutism that prevailed at the time it was difficult to see what such

talks could achieve. The British government, lacking clear political goals other than defence of the union, hoped to bring about a Provisional IRA ceasefire, an unrealistic aspiration given the lack of political gains it could offer the republican movement. Republicans believed that they could force British withdrawal and would settle for nothing less than notification of intent to withdraw.

Unsurprisingly the 1972 talks quickly collapsed, to be followed by increased violence. Republicans attempted to make Northern Ireland ungovernable through widespread attacks. 'Bloody Friday', a concerted bombing campaign in Belfast, followed the collapse of the Whitelaw talks. The British government asserted its authority by eliminating 'no go' areas through Operation Motorman, a move that made it more difficult for the IRA to operate. Twenty-five years later, greater sophistry on both sides, allied to political realism, offered a more fruitful agenda.

In 1973 the British government issued a white paper on the likely shape of a future settlement in Ireland (HM Government, 1973). Although the problem continued to be described as intractable for many years, the basis of an agreement was clear from that point onwards. A settlement would contain a Northern Ireland elected assembly, an Irish dimension and an Anglo-Irish intergovernmental arrangement. Outlining a possible solution was, of course, far easier than drawing republicans and loyalists into its framework. The essential difference between the Sunningdale Agreement of 1973 and the Good Friday Agreement of 1998 was that the former was based on the exclusion of paramilitary groups and their political representatives; the latter was based on their inclusion. The change was produced partly through policy learning by the British government, but was mainly facilitated by moderation of the republican agenda. In constitutional terms the agreements were broadly similar and the comment by Seamus Mallon that the Good Friday Agreement amounted to 'Sunningdale for slow learners' was apposite (Tonge, 2000). For a consociational settlement to work, however, there had to be some degree of loyalty to the state, or at least a willingness to abandon attempts at its overthrow. For republicans, this abandonment did not arrive until the 1990s.

The Sunningdale Agreement did not fail merely because of the marginalization of paramilitary groups; it also lacked majority support among the unionist community, as evidenced by the February 1974 British general election results, in which 11 of the 12 elected unionist MPs were opposed to the agreement. The Northern Ireland

Assembly elections in 1973 yielded 26 unionist opponents of power sharing with an Irish dimension, compared with 24 in favour. For unionist opponents the agreement contained an inherent contradiction, rectified 25 years later in the Good Friday version. The recognition by the Irish government that there could be no change in the status of the northern province unless a majority in Northern Ireland consented was undermined by its continuing constitutional claim to Northern Ireland, with the pursuit of 'national territory', later being declared a constitutional imperative of Irish governments by the courts.

What were the principles upon which the Sunningdale Agreement was based? Like the Good Friday Agreement, it was a three-stranded deal, comprising 'north–north' (Executive and Assembly), north–south (cross-border) and east–west (London–Dublin) arrangements. The agreement was based on the consociational idea of enforced power sharing via a grand coalition, as represented in the 1973–74 model by an executive comprising Faulkner (pro-agreement) unionists, the Alliance Party and the SDLP. The agreement also contained minority veto rights, but lacked specific measures for 'community autonomy', another feature of 'classic consociationalism' (Lijphart, 1977). The major difficulty confronting a consociational settlement in Northern Ireland – loyalty to another sovereign country by a sizeable section of the minority population – was addressed by the establishment of the Council of Ireland, with membership of this all-Ireland body being compulsory for members of the Northern Ireland executive. There was much ambiguity over the remit of the all-Ireland body. Famously, it was described by an SDLP member, Hugh Logue, as the 'vehicle by which Unionists would be trundled into a united Ireland' (quoted in Coogan, 1995, p. 177). This assertion, reflective of the thinking of a section of the SDLP leadership, did little to bolster unionist confidence or foster the development of nationalist loyalty to Northern Ireland, which would be essential to the long-term functioning of a consociational settlement.

The similarities between the Sunningdale and Good Friday Agreements, not merely in constitutional architecture but also in terms of the British policy approach, have led to the events in the 1972–74 period being labelled as the first peace process (Dixon, 2001). Yet although a political process was developed, a peace process was non-existent. While the IRA feared marginalization through the successful implementation of the Sunningdale Agreement and therefore attempted to increase its contact with loyalist paramilitary groups, there was

little prospect of the Provisionals abandoning the 'armed struggle' at that stage for a deal that fell so short of their avowed objectives. As such the political process continued, but it was devoid of realism in that it was based on the defeat of terrorists through their exclusion from the political framework. By the 1990s policy makers were prepared to countenance the idea that paramilitaries could be, if not defeated, then relatively comfortably accommodated within a power sharing arrangement, provided they were offered a stake in the system. The Provisionals did attempt a ceasefire in the mid 1970s, but this collapsed amid a growing tide of sectarian killings.

The collapse of the Sunningdale Agreement was followed by security-oriented efforts to defeat the IRA. Ulsterization – the attempted replacement of the British Army by the Royal Ulster Constabulary in parts of Northern Ireland – was perhaps less important than criminalization: the attempt to undermine the IRA's claim to be fighting a political war by treating IRA prisoners as common criminals. The denouement of criminalization was the republican hunger strike to achieve political status for prisoners in 1981, which transformed republicanism into a two-pronged movement of military action and electoral politics. Retrospectively, criminalization might be said to have been successful, in that it squeezed the IRA and set republicans on a political path that eventually led to abandonment of the military campaign. Nonetheless the late 1970s and early 1980s appeared to be a barren time for Northern Ireland politics. Local politicians were rendered impotent during a succession of security initiatives, which were followed by a modest Anglo-Irish intergovernmental cooperation in 1980 and a failed attempt to bring devolution back to Northern Ireland in 1982–86.

The attempt by James Prior, the reluctant secretary of state for Northern Ireland, to revive devolution in 1982 was doomed from the outset as even the SDLP was unwilling to participate in a reconstituted Northern Ireland Assembly. The SDLP derided the scheme as unworkable due to its lack of an all-Ireland dimension. In taking such a 'green' line the SDLP was conscious of the looming electoral rivalry with Sinn Fein. In the 1983 British general election, Sinn Fein won 100 000 votes and secured the election of Gerry Adams as MP for West Belfast.

The 1985 Anglo-Irish Agreement marked the climax of a period of intergovernmentalism that had begun in 1980, wobbled two years later and was revived under pressure from nationalists in 1984. With no prospect of local agreement, political initiatives had to be pursued via

Anglo-Irish governmental dialogue. Since 1972 the British government had conceded that it would be desirable for Northern Ireland policy to be approved by the Dublin government (HM Government, 1972), hence it was merely an incremental step for that government to be given consultative rights on northern policy. In this respect the Anglo-Irish Agreement amounted to policy continuity.

Constitutional nationalists had to be seen to be making gains if the electoral advance of Sinn Fein was to be checked. This produced a dawning community of interest between the two governments, given that Sinn Fein appeared to pose a radical threat to the security of the British and Irish states (Fraser, 2000). Partly at the behest of the SDLP, constitutional nationalists had met in 1983–84 to produce the New Ireland Forum Report. The report's conclusions were in many ways a restatement of traditional nationalist views. Certainly its recommendation for Irish unity, federalism or joint sovereignty had not the remotest hope of being adopted by the British government. The articulation of a fairly basic form of nationalism nonetheless pre-empted any possibility of the British government requesting the abandonment of the Irish Republic's 1937 constitutional claim, which might otherwise have been demanded by the moderate Fine Gael government led by Garret Fitzgerald. The Conservative government, hit hard by the IRA bombing at the Conservative Party Conference in Brighton in 1984, recognized that doing nothing was perhaps no longer an option. The Anglo-Irish Agreement placed the problem of Northern Ireland in a permanently binational context. Whilst it was true that 'almost everyone was surprised that Thatcher was prepared to sign such a document', the consultative rights awarded to the Irish government were arguably less than those which were to have been awarded to the Council of Ireland eleven years earlier (McKittrick and McVea, 2001: 163).

The Anglo-Irish Agreement also produced the last gasp of civil war politics in the Irish Republic. Although republicans partly blamed the Fine Gael government for the temporary breakdown of the peace process in 1996–97, there was little difference in substance between the two main Irish parties in respect of Northern Ireland. This perhaps makes all the more surprising the finding that members of Fine Gael still rated Northern Ireland as the issue over which their party differed most from Fianna Fail (Gallagher and Marsh, 2002, p. 182). In 1985, however, Charles Haughey, as leader of Fianna Fail, opposed the Anglo-Irish Agreement. Haughey argued that Article 1, which

indicated that there would be no change in the status of Northern Ireland without the consent of a majority of its citizens, was a unionist veto that 'copper fastened partition'. Indeed the agreement received only a modest majority of 88 votes to 75 in *Dail Eireann*. Haughey's opposition amounted to the final rhetorical flourish of the 'republican party' and Fianna Fail did little to oppose the agreement. Indeed by the time a formal review of the agreement was undertaken in 1989, Fianna Fail's dissent had been put aside. Given that even elements within Sinn Fein privately accepted that the agreement, although partitionist and counterinsurgent, did offer concessions and constituted a shift in British policy, it was difficult for Fianna Fail to oppose the deal. More important to Fianna Fail than the private agonies of Sinn Fein, however, was the fact that the agreement appeared to be popular with the electorate in the Irish Republic. A deal that aroused such vociferous unionist protest was seen as beneficial for nationalists.

Although the Anglo-Irish Agreement offered no obvious threat to Northern Ireland's place in the United Kingdom it prompted a hostile unionist response. Unionists believed that the agreement amounted to a 'slippery slope' to Irish unity, even though the consultative rights afforded to the Irish government, while comprehensive, were far short of the executive powers that might have indicated a shift to joint authority. The agreement was characterized by the extensiveness of the consultative rights rather than their intensity, and there would be no role for the Irish government in the actual governance of Northern Ireland. In effect it would serve as a consultative body on many aspects of how Northern Ireland ought to be governed. The agreement did serve to emphasize the conditionality of Northern Ireland's place in the United Kingdom, and that there would be no unionist veto over internal political developments in Northern Ireland. The agreement also highlighted that there would never be a return to the British government's 1969 position that the affairs of Northern Ireland were a purely internal concern. For the integrationist leader of the Ulster Unionist Party, James Molyneaux, an international agreement on the future of a supposedly integral part of the United Kingdom was anathema and he argued that unionists were 'going to be delivered, bound and trussed like a turkey ready for the oven, from one nation to another nation' (quoted in Arthur and Jeffery, 1996, p. 18). In an attempt to embarrass the Dublin government, the unionist McGimpsey brothers urged the Irish courts to rule the Anglo-Irish Agreement illegal as it breached the constitutional claim to Northern Ireland

lodged by the Irish Republic under Articles 2 and 3. The verdict of the courts was that British rule in Northern Ireland was a *de facto* reality, but that the pursuit of Irish unity via Articles 2 and 3 of the Irish constitution was still a requirement of Irish governments.

The agreement hinted at a reconstituted northern state, in which the Irish Republic might act as a guarantor of the rights and interests of the northern nationalist minority. Furthermore it represented the death of the integrationist aspirations held by sections of the UUP leadership as the Conservative government formally abandoned any hope of persuading nationalists to adopt a British identity. Although the Anglo-Irish Agreement, unlike its 1998 Good Friday successor, did not dwell on identity politics, its implication was clear: competing nationalisms within Northern Ireland could only be managed through that form of politics, managed at this stage by the two governments.

Despite a variety of obstructions by unionists, the agreement's permanent secretariat at Maryfield continued to undertake its business. The bulk of unionist opposition was based on the withdrawal from state institutions. Loyalist paramilitary groups were also revived by opposition to the agreement. The UDA, in particular, increased its actions, often in the form of killings conducted under its UFF cover. The UDA offered some serious political thought beyond the Anglo-Irish Agreement impasse, however, through the document *Common Sense*, issued by the New Ulster Political Research Group in 1987 (NUPRG, 1987). The document advocated proportionality in government and substantial protection for the nationalist minority. Meanwhile other loyalists, including mainly law-abiding rural evangelicals, flirted with extraconstitutional activities. Ian Paisley briefly offered support and leadership for Ulster Resistance, a movement that pledged to stay within the law but would operate as a 'third force' if there was any attempt to coerce loyalists to accept a united Ireland. For this section of loyalists, the duty to obey the state was important, provided that the state maintained its obligations to the citizenry. According to loyalists, the state had abandoned this covenant by enforcing the Anglo-Irish Agreement (Bruce, 1994).

The unionist siege mentality was exacerbated by the tentative steps taken towards pan-nationalism in 1988 under the Hume–Adams initiative. Loyalist paramilitaries responded by increasing the targeting of republicans and threatening action against members of the 'pan-nationalist front'. Whilst enticing republicans to come in from the political wilderness, the secretary of state, Peter Brooke, did little to

reassure unionists when he asserted in 1989 that Britain had 'no selfish strategic or economic interest' in Northern Ireland. Brooke's words were hardly encouraging to unionists, and his declaration that the role of the British government was to encourage 'free democratic choice' merely highlighted the continuing centrality of the 'consent principle' in respect of the future constitutional status of Northern Ireland (Mallie and McKittrick, 1996, p. 107). Unionist recognition of the futility of continuing to oppose to the Anglo-Irish Agreement arrived early, via the *An End to Drift* document of 1987, but there were few political developments, other than a 1989 review of the agreement, until the bilateral Brooke talks with political parties in 1991. These talks collapsed before proceeding to the 'strand two' discussions on the future role of the Irish government (Arthur, 1992). Although they did not progress far, the Brooke talks heralded a three-stranded approach in subsequent discussions, based on the future of, respectively, Northern Ireland, Northern Ireland–Irish Republic and British–Irish relations.

Brooke's successor, Patrick Mayhew, revived the bilateral talks soon after his appointment in April 1992 (indeed the discussions are often referred to as the Brooke–Mayhew talks). Mayhew's attempt to make political progress also ended in failure as the talks were abandoned in November. The main difficulty had been the reluctance of the Irish government to commit itself to a referendum on the scrapping of Articles 2 and 3 of its constitution. Without a guarantee of this, unionists were not prepared to enter into any negotiations on cross-border arrangements. Mayhew attempted to reassure the unionists by insisting that he would not contemplate 'any change to the status of Northern Ireland that does not represent the self-determination of the people living in Northern Ireland' (quoted in Elliott and Flackes, 1999, p. 349). The parameters of a prospective settlement were now apparent: consent within Northern Ireland for constitutional change, abandonment of the Irish Republic's constitutional claim to Northern Ireland, a power-sharing arrangement in the north, economic cross-border institutions and a continuing British–Irish intergovernmental arrangement. However the balance of these factors was far from clear. It was not yet obvious that republicans would accept an arrangement that fell too far short of joint authority, let alone relinquish their traditional demand for an independent, united Ireland. Brooke and Mayhew's private communications with the IRA had yet to be made public, but such contacts indicated that an end to the war was sought and that republicans *might* compromise their long-held ambitions.

By December 1993 the British and Irish governments were in a position to outline the broad set of principles upon which a settlement would be based. The Downing Street Declaration, couched in the green language of Irish self-determination but coated in the unionist demand for consent, was sufficiently appealing to paramilitary groups to mark the beginning of the end of the Troubles.

Between 1969 and 1998 the conflict was seen as one of low intensity, but if it were applied proportionately to the entire population of the United Kingdom it would have produced 111 000 deaths (Hayes and McAllister, 2000). While the Troubles were not borne of an enduring vision of an independent and united Irish Republic, the allegiance of the Provisional IRA leadership to this vision provided a framework within which nationalist discontent with the northern state could be harnessed. Such discontent was sparked mainly by the majoritarian and sectarian nature of the unionist administration in Northern Ireland, in which a recognizable system of government and opposition failed to emerge. Nationalist abstention and the nature of the southern state did not help north–south or intercommunal relations, but the key point was that any rotation of power was unthinkable.

Discrimination against nationalists was largely the product of fear of a republican resurgence and partly due to the distaste for Catholics held by a sizeable proportion of the ruling Unionist Party, in which membership of the Orange Order was of considerable importance. This political and religious hostility inhibited some in unionist politics from supporting a modest reform programme in the 1960s, as demanded by the civil rights movement. The failure to accommodate protest ensured its rapid translation into armed insurrection. Although the outline of an accommodation with the nationalist community had emerged by 1973, British insistence on the defeat of terrorism and the republican assertion of fundamentalist ideals combined to prevent a settlement until 1998. The 1970s and 1980s constituted a period of ideological politics, in which republicanism offered a holistic vision of an independent Ireland, pitted against unionist integrationist or majority rule ideals. The 1990s witnessed the development of identity politics, under which competing national identities and aspirations came to be respected by both sides. This new emphasis on identity politics created space for the application of consociational principles in the 1998 Good Friday Agreement. Power could be shared and community identity recognized through new institutions.